

The First Few Minutes: When a Student Loses It

For the adult in the room right after a blow-up. Your response, the room, and the referral. Not what caused it, and not a technique to deliver to the student.

CLASSROOM MANAGEMENT

READ IT

Before you need it

PREP

None

Check safety first

- **If anyone could get hurt:** That comes before everything below. Get another adult. Physical restraint or seclusion is not a de-escalation tool: it is restricted to imminent danger, and only trained staff should use it. [NASP 2021]

Your response comes first

- **Lower your voice:** Slow your movements, keep instructions few and clear, and state plainly what behaviour you expect right now. [NCTSN, Psychological First Aid for Schools]
- **Hold the boundary without piling on:** Set a firm limit on the behaviour. Decide any consequence after things are calm, logically rather than punitively, and not as part of the blow-up. [NCTSN, Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators, p.5]

GIVE ONE SAFE CHOICE

Loss of control is often part of what the student is reacting to. Offer one real, small choice, where to sit or whether to stand by the door, instead of a string of instructions. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.5]

Do not assume you know the reason

- Blowing up at correction, or fighting when criticised, can be a trauma reaction rather than defiance. That does not remove the boundary above. It should stop you deciding you know the cause before anyone trained has looked. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.4]

After the moment, not during it

- **Support, then refer:** Once things are calm, offer support yourself if you can, or refer the student to your counsellor or school mental health professional. [NCTSN PFA for Schools, Core Action 3]
- **Give it a time and a place:** Set aside an actual time to talk about what happened, rather than processing it in front of the class. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.5]

When to escalate

- If the reaction was severe, or this keeps happening, refer it. You do not need to be certain what is behind it first. Let a school mental health professional make that call. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.6]
- If you suspect abuse behind what you saw, follow your school reporting procedure, separately and without waiting on anything above. [NCTSN Toolkit, p.4; your district policy governs the procedure]

TIP

Not on this card, on purpose: breathing exercises, calming scripts, or any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.